“I don’t want to be this or that person. I love the way I am.”

Much like the form versus function discourse, the Mumbai vs Delhi argument has been a never ending volley. However, if there is one person who has upended this debate in recent times, and in favour of Delhi, it is Shalini Passi. Literally storming the bastion of reality television, she has become an overnight sensation, with the most quotable lines, sound byes that went viral almost immediately and the highest recall value for any of the six stars outlining the Netflix show *Fabulous Lives Vs Bollywood Wives*. Passi confesses that despite an extremely fulfilling life and career, this has been a born-again moment for her. “I’d like to see it as a rebirth—one that hopefully brings more opportunities and success,” says Passi, who has metamorphosed from being a diffident and reclusive art patron and collector to a shooting star. “Stepping in front of the camera helped me uncover a new side to myself. Before 2018, I had a phobia of the camera and was incredibly shy. Overcoming that fear led me to embark on an inward journey, as well as a physical one that took me to places as varied as Ladakh, Bikaner, Jaipur, Jodhpur, and Mahabalipuram for various shoots—a transformative experience in itself.”

While Passi’s whimsical personality and quirky witticisms have earned her a legion of fans, it was her self-confidence and ability to stand her ground and still love herself on the show—in the face of much ambient noise—that truly offered life lessons. “I guess it’s a matter of knowing who you are and being comfortable in your skin and space. Self-discovery is an ongoing journey. Sometimes we feel we’ve made progress, yet realise we’re still in the middle; other times, we may think we’ve reached our destination only to find we’re just beginning. The human experience is a continuous path of growth and learning, and I see myself as an ever-evolving part of that journey,” adds Passi.

In line with this journey, she founded MASH, a digital platform that explores the



Shalini Passi